

All figures sourced from Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

Building Up: A Blueprint for the Alberta Accessibility and Inclusion Act

Part One — What Real Accessibility and Inclusion Actually Look Like

Section 1.1 — Definition: What Accessibility and Inclusion Mean

Before any blueprint can be built, the terms have to be defined. Public conversation about disability frequently uses *accessibility* and *inclusion* interchangeably. They are not interchangeable. They describe two distinct obligations a province owes its disabled population, and a system can deliver one without delivering the other. This document treats both as binding standards. Both must be defined before either can be measured.

Accessibility

Accessibility is the removal of barriers in the physical, communicational, technological, programmatic, and attitudinal environments that prevent disabled people from participating in society on equal terms with non-disabled people. The Government of Canada's *Accessible Canada Act* (2019) defines barriers as anything — physical, architectural, technological, attitudinal, information-based, communication-based, or policy-based — that hinders the full and equal participation in society of persons with an impairment. The federal definition is comprehensive on purpose. It recognizes that disability is not located in the disabled body. Disability is produced by the interaction between the body and an environment that was not designed to include it.

The United Nations *Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities* (UN CRPD), ratified by Canada in 2010 and binding on all provinces including Alberta, establishes accessibility as a core principle and a state obligation. Article 9 of the Convention requires States Parties to identify and eliminate obstacles and barriers to accessibility across the built environment, transportation, information and communications, and services open to the public. The obligation is not aspirational. It is a treaty commitment.

Accessibility, in operational terms, means a ramp where stairs would exclude a wheelchair user. It means plain-language documents where Grade-16 legalese would exclude a reader with a cognitive disability. It means a captioned video where audio-only content would exclude a Deaf viewer. It means a phone tree that offers a human option where automated menus would exclude a person with a brain injury, severe anxiety, or aphasia. It means a form that can be completed without a working printer, a stable internet connection, or a current driver's license. It means a public transit system that arrives where disabled people live and travels where they need to go. It means a hospital that provides interpretation, sensory accommodation, and physical access. It means a courtroom that can be entered, heard, and addressed by a person with any combination of physical, sensory, cognitive, or psychiatric disability.

Accessibility is the floor. It is the minimum a province must build for disabled people to be present in it.

Inclusion

All figures sourced from Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

Inclusion is the further obligation. Accessibility removes the barriers that exclude. Inclusion ensures that disabled people, once present, are full participants — that their presence is welcomed, their contributions valued, their needs met, their autonomy respected, and their humanity recognized as equal in every domain of life.

A wheelchair user can enter a building with a ramp. That is accessibility. Whether they are listened to in the meeting they came to attend, whether their ideas are credited, whether they are invited back, whether the agenda includes the topics they raised — that is inclusion. A Deaf student can attend a school with interpretation services. That is accessibility. Whether the curriculum reflects Deaf culture and history, whether Deaf staff are hired, whether the social environment of the school treats Deaf identity as fully equal to hearing identity — that is inclusion. A person with intellectual disability can apply for a job through an accessible application process. That is accessibility. Whether they are hired, mentored, advanced, paid equitably, and treated as a colleague rather than a charitable accommodation — that is inclusion.

The UN CRPD frames inclusion through the principle of *full and effective participation and inclusion in society* (Article 3, General Principles). Inclusion is not a sentiment. It is a structural commitment that disabled people will be present, heard, decisive, and equal in every space the non-disabled population occupies — including the spaces where decisions are made about disabled people's own lives.

Inclusion is the standard. Accessibility makes it possible. Inclusion makes it real.

What the Distinction Means in Practice

A province can deliver accessibility without delivering inclusion. Alberta currently does this routinely. Government buildings have ramps. Government websites have alt-text on some images. Government forms exist in PDF formats that can, in theory, be read by screen readers. These are accessibility features, often partial, sometimes effective. They are not inclusion. Disabled Albertans remain absent from senior decision-making positions in the ministries that govern their lives. The Premier's Council on the Status of Persons with Disabilities — Alberta's only formal mechanism for disabled-led advisory input to government — was defunded in 2020. The Disability Action Hall, which had organized disabled Albertans for twenty-eight years, lost its core funding in 2024. The advocacy organizations that translate community knowledge into policy input have been systematically cut. Accessibility, where it exists, exists alongside the deliberate removal of inclusion.

A province can also fail at both. Alberta does this in many domains. The AISH application requires forms written at a Grade-12-to-16 reading level for a population whose largest single diagnostic categories are mental illness and cognitive disability. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities (FSCD) program operates with wait times that approach three years in some regions, foreclosing access to interventions that are clinically time-bound. The Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program serves adult Albertans with intellectual disability through waitlists that have not moved in years. None of these are inclusion failures alone. They are accessibility failures first — the basic removal of barriers has not been done — and inclusion failures second, because the population that would have demanded better has been organized out of the conversation.

All figures sourced from Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

The blueprint this document builds requires both. Accessibility is the floor. Inclusion is the standard. A fair province delivers both, in every domain, to every disability category, at every life stage. Anything less is not reform. It is the maintenance of exclusion under the language of progress.

The Social Model and the Lived-Experience Definition

Underlying both accessibility and inclusion is the social model of disability — the framework, developed by disabled scholars and activists in the late twentieth century, that disability is produced by the interaction between an impaired body and an excluding environment, not by the impairment alone. The medical model treats disability as an individual problem to be cured, accommodated, or managed. The social model treats disability as a social problem to be removed by changing the environment. Both models have legitimate uses. Medical care is essential and the medical model captures that. But policy designed around the medical model alone produces what Alberta has now: a system that treats disabled Albertans as broken individuals to be processed, rather than as full citizens whose exclusion is the system's problem to solve.

The lived-experience definition is the third anchor. Disabled people themselves — through lifelong knowledge of what their conditions actually require, what supports actually work, what barriers actually exclude, and what inclusion actually looks like — hold expertise that no clinical or policy training can replicate. Real accessibility and inclusion cannot be designed without disabled people in the design rooms. The phrase *Nothing About Us Without Us*, originating in disability rights organizing in the 1990s and adopted by the UN CRPD as a guiding principle, captures the standard. Alberta's current disability policy architecture has been built largely without disabled-led advisory input, and the consequences are visible in every program the document examines.

WORKING DEFINITIONS FOR THIS BLUEPRINT

Accessibility is the systemic removal of physical, communicational, technological, programmatic, and attitudinal barriers that prevent disabled Albertans from participating in society on equal terms with non-disabled Albertans. It is a treaty obligation under the UN CRPD and a statutory standard under the federal *Accessible Canada Act*. It is the floor.

Inclusion is the systemic guarantee that disabled Albertans, once present in any space, will be full participants — heard, valued, decisive, and equal — across every domain of life, including the rooms where decisions about disabled people are made. It is the standard the floor exists to reach.

Real accessibility and inclusion are distinguished from performative versions by three tests: are the barriers actually removed in the lived experience of disabled people; are disabled people actually present and decisive in the rooms that govern their lives; and is the framework grounded in lived expertise rather than imposed from outside it. A province that fails any of the three tests has not delivered real accessibility and inclusion. It has delivered the appearance of them.

All figures sourced from Government of Alberta open data, Statistics Canada, federal statute, UN treaty, and peer-reviewed research.

What This Section Establishes

The remainder of Part One applies these definitions to the lifecycle of a disabled Albertan — from the developmental window of early childhood through the transition to adulthood, the operation of provincial support programs, the role of family caregivers, and the moment of acquired disability — and measures Alberta's current performance against the standard the definitions establish.

A Note on What Comes Next

The lifecycle frame that follows is not a description of disability as a category. What Disability Actually Means, the campaign's existing reference document, performs that function and remains the companion text to this one. The lifecycle frame in Part One is the description of the architecture a province should build to support disability across a human life, and the systematic gap analysis between that architecture and what Alberta currently provides. The argument is structural. The evidence is sourced. The conclusion is that Alberta's current direction is not the absence of architecture. It is the active dismantling of architecture that other Canadian provinces have built, the federal government has built at the national level, and international human rights law has bound Canada to maintain.

Part One documents what is being dismantled, why it matters, and what should replace it.